

BEEFING UP Intelligence

If terror strikes have to be thwarted, intelligence gathering has to be coordinated and actionable

ISSUE
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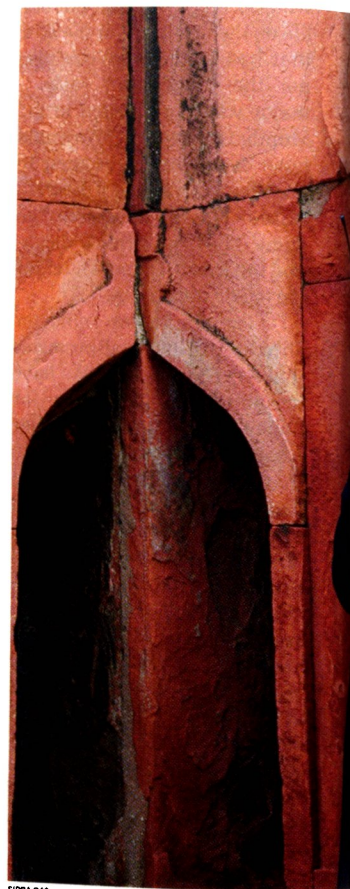
When P. Chidambaram took over as Home Minister, he felt the key to raising the preparedness level was in gathering and sharing of intelligence. But he was in for a shock when he reviewed the state of India's intelligence agencies. The multiplicity of organisations involved in intelligence-gathering refused to share the information, despite the establishment of a Multi-Agency Centre (MAC) to act as a nodal point as far back as 2001. So among the first things he did was to make the MAC function on a 24x7 basis and make it a legal requirement for it to share intelligence with other agencies.

Much of the problem is because India has not learnt its lessons. The Kargil Review Committee, which went into the massive failure of intelligence that saw Pakistani intruders take the mountain heights without the Indian army knowing, stated: "There is no institutionalised mechanism for coordination or objective-oriented interaction between intelligence agencies and consumers at different levels. Similarly,

there is no mechanism for tasking the agencies, monitoring their performance and reviewing their records to evaluate their quality. Nor is there any oversight of the overall functioning of the agencies." Despite its report, reform in intelligence agencies was slow in coming. So we had Mumbai 26/11. The problem is that nearly a dozen agencies operate side-by-side in silos where intelligence follows a down-up approach.

The agencies rarely ever communicate and jealously guard their turf. There is no real time gathering or sharing of intelligence. Agencies act more like post-offices when they receive information. The Joint Intelligence Council (JIC) was set up to collate the intelligence from various organisations, but never did so.

R&AW was set up four decades ago on the lines of the CIA—an eclectic collection of experts from various fields who were rigorously trained in spy-craft and by the late 1970s, had even penetrated Pakistan's nascent nuclear weapons programme. But when I.K. Gujral took over as prime minister in the late '90s he asked the intel-



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ligence agencies to disband all covert activities against neighbouring countries. That saw the loss of key R&AW assets in Pakistan that had been nurtured over the years.

The "Gary" Saxena Committee on intelligence revamp had recommended that at least 30,000 personnel should be engaged in field duty in the IB. However, the total strength of IB is 25,000, of which almost one-third comprise drivers, peons, administrative and secretarial staff. The field strength is 3,500, of which a large number is engaged in political intelligence.

While talking about intelli-

THE LOCAL POLICE STATION IS THE BEST SOURCE OF INFORMATION AND AND IT NEEDS TO BE AT THE CENTRE OF THE INTELLIGENCE MACHINERY